

# Growth, Water Scarcity, and Long-Term Supply In Nevada

## WHAT THIS BRIEF IS ABOUT

This preliminary Legislative Brief shows what a completed briefing package looks like using **Nevada Legislature Information System (NELIS) bill-discovery data only**. It synthesizes the **stated purpose and drafting language** visible in NELIS bill titles for water-related measures filed in the 2019, 2021, 2023, and 2025 regular sessions. It is not a deliberation guide and not the final Version 0 brief. A separate clean Version 0 will be built when enriched action, vote, sponsor, and enactment data are ready. Where NELIS does not supply a needed fact, this brief states **INSUFFICIENT DATA**.

## KEY STATISTICS

147

Unique water-related bills identified in NELIS title/summary search across four sessions. [S4]

36

Water-related bills in the 80th (2019) Regular Session NELIS search set. [S4]

33

Water-related bills in the 81st (2021) Regular Session NELIS search set. [S4]

36

Water-related bills in the 82nd (2023) Regular Session NELIS search set. [S4]

42

Water-related bills in the 83rd (2025) Regular Session NELIS search set. [S4]

## BILL THEMES AND DRAFTING LANGUAGE

NELIS records used here include identifier, session, title, and source URL only. Purpose statements below are inferred from title language (including BDR chapter cues such as BDR 48-...). Enacted impact, votes, and sponsors are **INSUFFICIENT DATA**. [S4]

| Theme family                        | What title language suggests                                    | Illustrative bills                                                          | Purpose clue (title only)                                                 | Impact / outcome  |
|-------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|
| General water statute revisions     | "Revises provisions governing/relating to/related to water"     | AB30, AB51, AB62, AB95 (2019); AB19, AB20 (2023)                            | Amend existing water law chapters rather than name a single program       | INSUFFICIENT DATA |
| Groundwater basins & boards         | "groundwater," "basin," "boards," "management plans"            | SB140 (2019); SB149 (2021); SB112, SB113, SB176, SB180 (2023); AB363 (2025) | Change basin governance, assessments, boards, or groundwater conservation | INSUFFICIENT DATA |
| Water rights, diversion, dedication | "water rights," "diversion," "appropriated water," "dedication" | SB236, SB250 (2019); AB6 (2021)                                             | Adjust rights administration or change-of-use process                     | INSUFFICIENT DATA |
| Water conservation                  | "water conservation" (distinct from DNCR agency titles)         | AB163 (2019); AB191, AB220 (2023); AB134 (2025)                             | Revise or establish conservation provisions                               | INSUFFICIENT DATA |
| Colorado River institutions         | "Colorado River Commission," "Bureau of Reclamation"            | SB76 (2019); AB15 (2021); SJR3 (2023)                                       | Change CRC services/membership or memorialize a federal request           | INSUFFICIENT DATA |
| Planning, drought, studies          | "drought resiliency," "planning," "study," "recycling"          | SB499, AB265 (2019)                                                         | Create advisory capacity or commission research                           | INSUFFICIENT DATA |
| Agency capacity / appropriations    | Appropriations to Division of Water Resources or DNCR           | SB509 (2019); AB465 (2021); SB102, SB472, SB473 (2023)                      | Fund vehicles, software, or related agency operations                     | INSUFFICIENT DATA |

## STATE OF PLAY

Nevada's water pressures sit at the intersection of Colorado River reliability, groundwater basin management, conservation rules, and growth-related demand. [S1][S2] Southern Nevada's supply picture is tied to Colorado River conditions and related institutions; rural and northern questions often appear through groundwater, rights, and basin tools in bill titles. [S2][S4]

Across four sessions, NELIS search finds a steady cadence of water-tagged filings (roughly three dozen per session, 42 in 2025). Generic statute-revision titles are common, while groundwater, rights, conservation, and Colorado River institutions recur as named themes. [S4]

**INSUFFICIENT DATA** for which bills received committee votes, floor votes, crossed over, received second-chamber action, or were signed into law. Those milestones are outside the NELIS discovery fields used for this preliminary package. [S4]

Agency/LCB context documents frame why scarcity appears on the calendar (including data-center background), but they do not identify which of the 147 bills passed. [S3]

## HOW THIS WORKS IN NEVADA (INSTITUTIONS NAMED IN SOURCES)

Collected agency materials place water administration with the State Engineer / Division of Water Resources under state law, including water-rights and groundwater tools. [S1] Southern Nevada supply context includes SNWA description of Colorado River dependence. [S2] Bill titles also name the Colorado River Commission of Nevada and, in at least one resolution, the U.S. Bureau of Reclamation. [S4] A local land-use approval does not by itself create new water; water availability remains a distinct legal and physical question. [S1][S2]

## WHAT IS CURRENTLY BEING INTRODUCED (FROM NELIS TITLES)

**Conservation and general water statute work.** Repeated “revises provisions ... water” and “water conservation” titles indicate incremental statutory drafting. [S4]

**Groundwater management.** Titles on basins, boards, assessments, management plans, and groundwater conservation recur from 2019 through 2025. [S4]

**Colorado River / CRC interface.** CRC service and membership bills plus a 2023 Reclamation-focused joint resolution. [S4]

**Rights and agency capacity.** Diversion/dedication/appropriation-change titles, plus DWR appropriations for equipment and systems. [S4]

## ASSEMBLY VIABILITY INDICATORS (PRELIMINARY)

Evidence from NELIS titles alone suggests water scarcity and long-term supply remain active legislative subjects, with recurring drafting around groundwater, rights, conservation, and Colorado River institutions. [S4] Data gaps prevent assessment of enactment rates, bipartisan sponsorship, or which draft approaches most often survive committee.

## KEY DATA GAPS

- Committee votes (origin chamber)
- Floor votes (origin chamber)
- Crossover and second-chamber committee/floor votes
- Individual yes/no/other votes
- Primary sponsors and cosponsors
- Signed-into-law / chapter / veto outcomes
- Twenty-year enacted-policy impact analysis
- Full bill digests beyond NELIS title lines

## SELECTED SOURCES

Source key: S sources are public materials used for factual or background claims. Citation form below follows Chicago notes-bibliography style, keyed for brief use. Process inputs from Phase 2 Issue Briefs are not used as legislative facts in this NELIS-only package.

[S1] Nevada Division of Water Resources. “Water Planning.” *Nevada Division of Water Resources*. Accessed July 13, 2026. <https://water.nv.gov/programs/water-planning>.

[S2] Southern Nevada Water Authority. “Where Your Water Comes From.” *Southern Nevada Water Authority*. Accessed July 13, 2026. <https://www.snwa.com/water-resources/where-water-comes-from/>.

**[S3]** Nevada Legislative Counsel Bureau. *Data Centers Background Information*. Interim committee document no. 32531. Nevada Legislature. <https://www.leg.state.nv.us/App/InterimCommittee/REL/Document/32531>.

**[S4]** Nevada Legislature. Nevada Electronic Legislative Information System (NELIS). Bill search compilation for the 80th–83rd Regular Sessions, water-related measures. Accessed July 13, 2026. <https://www.leg.state.nv.us/App/NELIS/>. Individual bills listed in Appendix A.